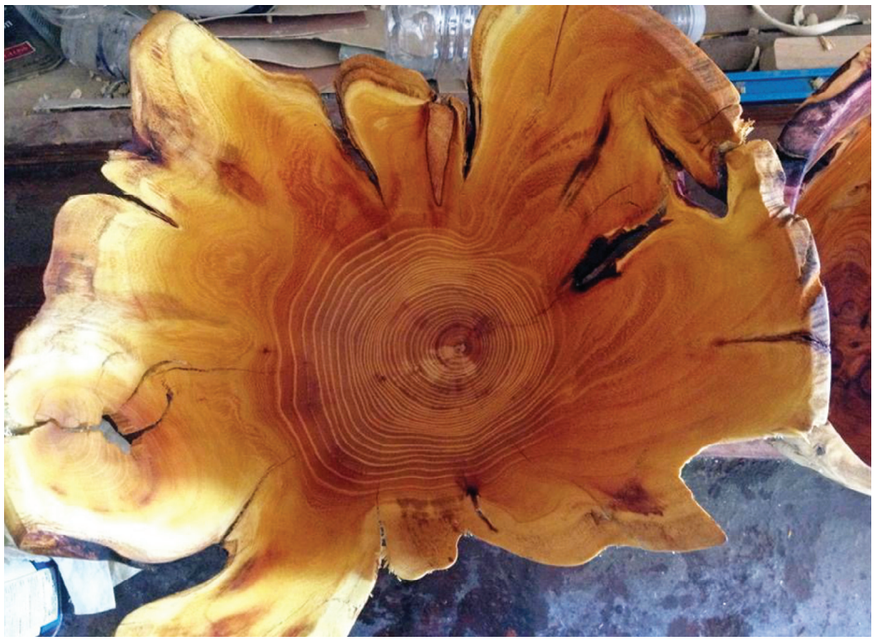

Cherry (*Prunus avium*) rootball vessel

ABOVE: Cherry crock rim-style bowl

LEFT: Cherry segmented hollow vessel

BELOW: Hackberry loose lid box and walnut loose lid box

advanced to more complex work. "I'll try anything or figure out a way to turn it blind style", he says. "I have gone from simple to more complex, thicker to thinner, and small to large or visa versa if it is challenging." He describes his style as "a freelance or free spirit style. The wood tells me what shape or turning it will become."

Michael relies on his sense of touch when making a piece: "Since I have never seen a turned piece or any of my bowls or pieces that I have turned, I feel the piece. Everything has a feel about the piece that brings an image to my mind that comes out in my work."

Inspirations and influences

Michael told us that he feels inspired by the challenges of woodturning: "I love learning and attempting all types of techniques." Woodturning clubs have had a great influence on his work. "I didn't know that they existed. I discovered woodturners at tool shows and would pick their brains about turning. Woodturners are the nicest people and they told me about woodturning clubs. I now belong to two clubs, Lincoln Land Woodturners in Springfield, Illinois and Woodturners of St. Louis, Missouri. So many woodturners have helped me to improve my skills, have given me ideas and have made me a better turner. I want to thank all of them."

Workshop and tools

Michael's workshop is in his garage. He has a Powermatic and Jet lathe, a tablesaw, planer, bandsaw, joiner, chainsaw, mitre saw and all the equipment that a woodworker needs. "I use these tools all by myself in the dark. Everything is arranged in a specific place and is not moved so that I can find what I need. I know exactly where everything is in the garage."

His essential tools are the lathe, 12mm bowl gauge, 12mm scraper, grinder and sandpaper. "I always tell my wife that I don't want any more tools, I need them!" he says.

He spends roughly six to eight hours a day in his workshop, he turns for a few hours, then spends time cleaning, sanding and finishing. As a blind turner, it takes him a little longer to make an item. A typical simple bowl takes him between one and one-and-a-half hours to complete.

To aid in his turning, Michael has modified an adjustable circle hole cutter to enable him to turn any size of tendon easily. To do this, Michael took the drill bit out of the centre and discarded it. He then turned the cutter around 180° in its holder. Instead of cutting a hole, it now cuts a straight tendon or spigot the chosen size every time. If you need a dovetail, a pass with a slew with create it. This device

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